HOW WE PLAY FOOTBALL

COACH'S GUIDE

9V9 FORMATION GUIDE

2-2-3-1

A starting shape, four playing principles and a job for every position.

INSIDE

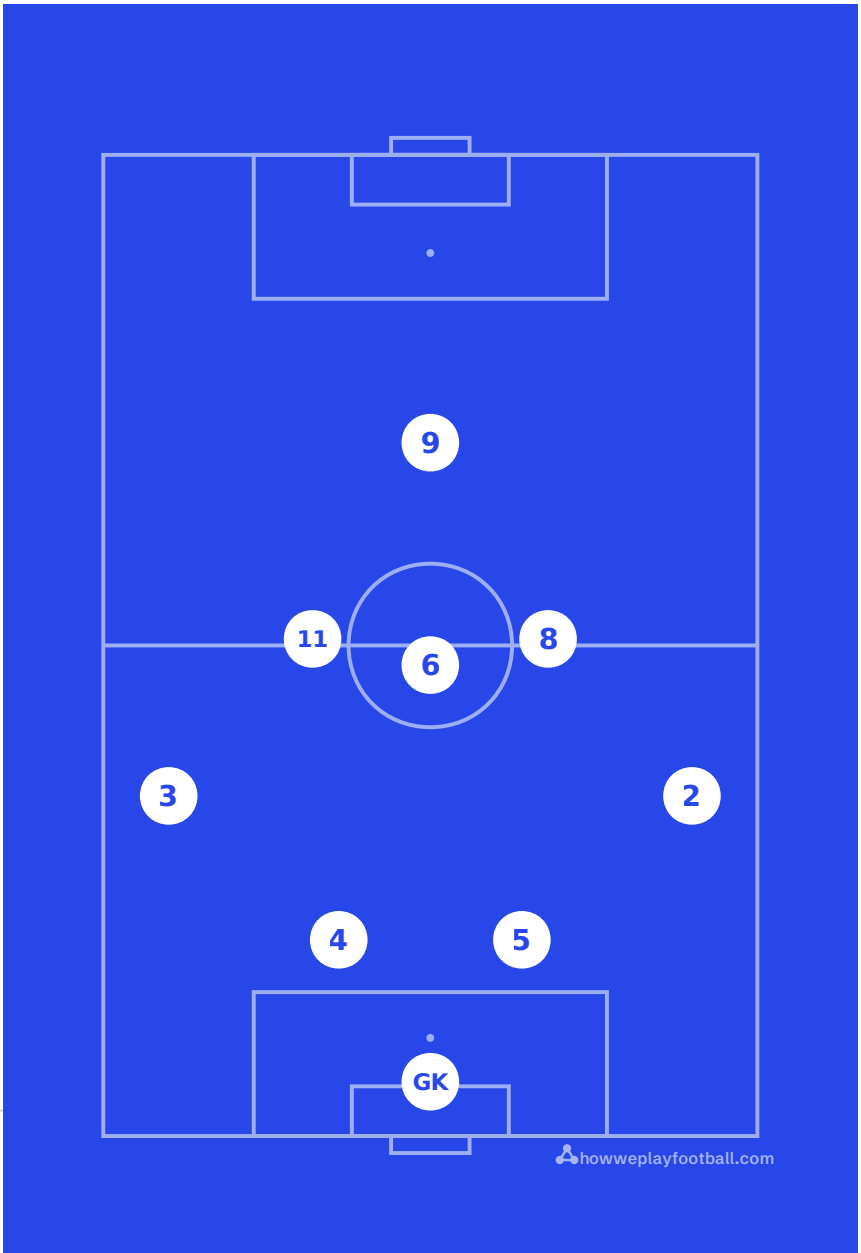
01 Starting shape

02 Four playing principles

03 A job for every player

04 Coaching reminders

THE FORMATION IS OUR STARTING PICTURE. IT ISN'T WHERE WE HAVE TO STAND.



INTRODUCTION

WELCOME

An alternative way to organise nine players: two central defenders, two wing-backs, three midfielders and a striker. It asks for careful cover and realistic recovery runs.

WHO IT'S FOR

Volunteer grassroots football coaches and parents looking for a shared starting picture for 9v9.

The shape helps us explain jobs. Players should still have opportunities to try different roles.

HOW TO USE IT

- Learn the starting shape.
- Pick one of the four principles to talk about.
- Give each player a short, useful question.
- Use the online diagrams when you want to see movement.

IN THIS GUIDE

01 Starting shape

02 Four playing principles

03 A job for every player

04 Coaching reminders and notes

A CLEAR SHAPE. SIMPLE DECISIONS. ROOM FOR CHILDREN TO LEARN.

HOW TO READ THIS GUIDE

READING THE DIAGRAMS

We always attack up the page. These pictures capture a moment, not a fixed running lane.

8

OUR PLAYER

A blue player with a number.

THEM

A player from the opposition.

BALL

Where the ball is in this moment.

MOVEMENT

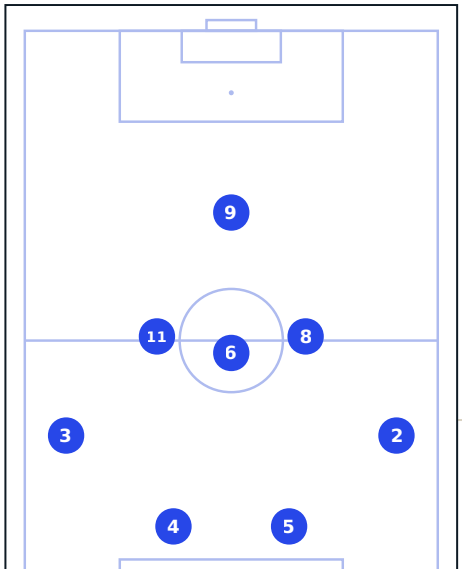
A solid arrow shows a possible run.

PASS

A broken arrow can show a pass.

SPACE

A highlighted area draws your eye to a decision.



9V9 · 2-2-3-1

A STARTING SHAPE, NOT A FIXED PLAN FOR EVERY SECOND.

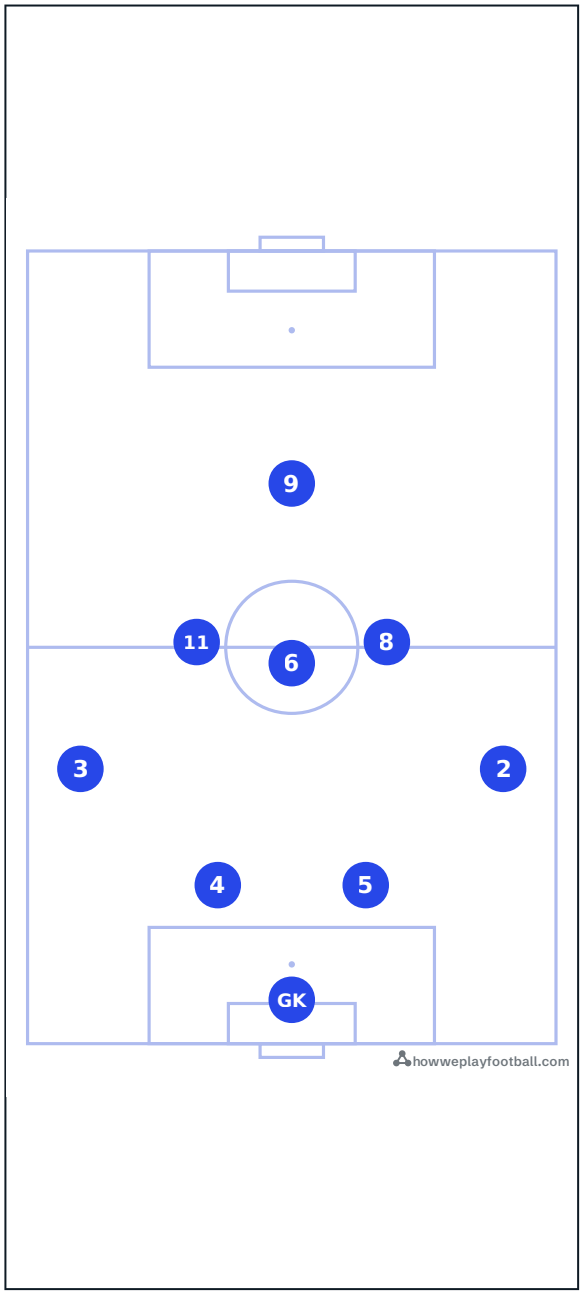
The numbers identify jobs in the drawings. They do not lock children into one position.

Illustrative diagrams, not pitch plans drawn to scale.

CHAPTER 01 · THE STARTING PICTURE

STARTING SHAPE

An alternative way to organise nine players: two central defenders, two wing-backs, three midfielders and a striker. It asks for careful cover and realistic recovery runs.



THIS SHAPE GIVES US

- possible wide support from two wing-backs
- three midfielders who may connect passes centrally
- one forward offering a higher passing option
- opportunities to discuss when players support and recover

REMEMBER

SAME STARTING SHAPE. DIFFERENT DECISIONS AS THE BALL MOVES.

9v9 · The 2-2-3-1 · Indicative player starting positions

CHAPTER 01 · THE STARTING PICTURE

A JOB FOR EVERYONE

The numbers help us talk about where to start. The actual decision depends on the ball, the opposition and our teammates.

GK GOALKEEPER
See danger early

4 · 5 CENTRAL DEFENDERS
Protect each other

3 · 2 WING-BACKS
Two jobs, one decision

6 CENTRAL MIDFIELDER
Our connection and protection

11 · 8 INTERIOR MIDFIELDERS
Make angles, not crowds

9 STRIKER
Give us a way forward

THE BIG PICTURE

Each position has a simple job. The four principles help those jobs fit together.

CHAPTER 02 · HOW WE PLAY

FOUR PRINCIPLES

Small decisions the whole team can recognise and talk about.

01 TWO STAY CONNECTED

Our centre-backs defend together. The two defenders recognise pressure and cover as a partnership.

“Am I close enough to help?”

02 WIDTH WITH COVER

Wing-backs go when someone can protect behind. Width can help our attack, but it changes the space we must defend.

“If I go, who covers?”

03 SOMEONE PROTECTS THE MIDDLE

Don't leave the route to our goal open. A player must notice central danger when teammates support near the ball.

“Who is stopping the pass through?”

04 LOSE IT? FIND HOME

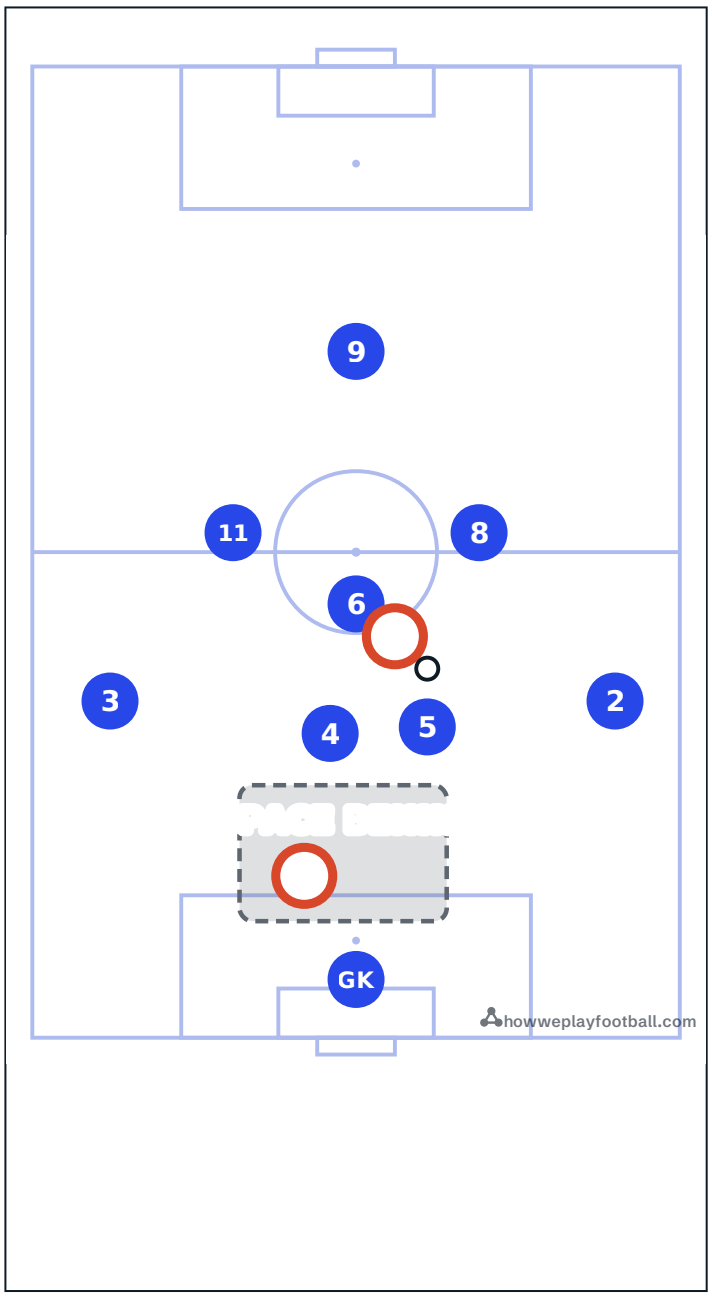
Press if you can, recover if you can't. After losing the ball, choose the nearest useful defensive job.

“Press, protect or recover: which is my job?”

CHAPTER 02 · PRINCIPLE 01 OF 04

TWO STAY CONNECTED

Our centre-backs defend together. The two defenders recognise pressure and cover as a partnership.



PICTURE 1 OF 2

BOTH GO

Example: both central defenders step towards the same opponent, potentially exposing space behind.

SAY IT ON THE TOUCHLINE

“AM I CLOSE ENOUGH TO HELP?”

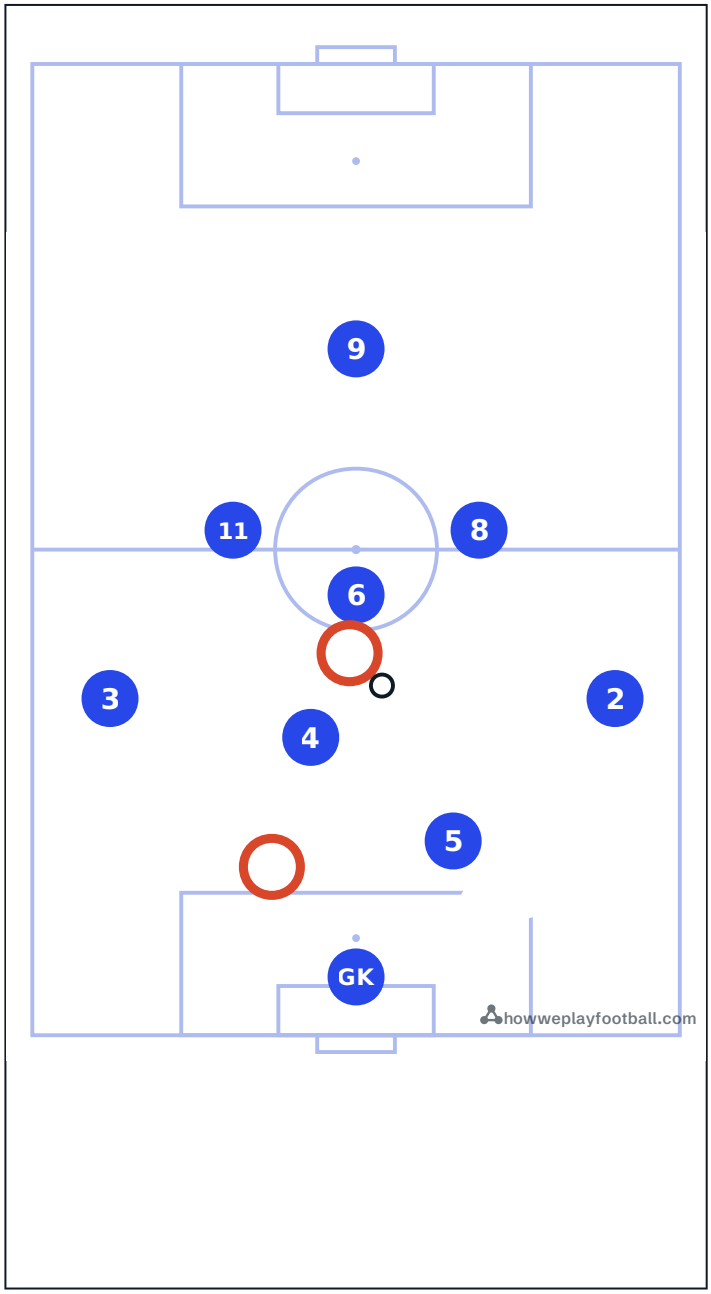
One may have to challenge while the other is ready to cover.

Move from the first picture to the next to discuss the decision. The drawings are illustrative, not fixed moves.

CHAPTER 02 · PRINCIPLE 01 OF 04

LOOK FOR THIS

Three things to notice when your players make this decision.



PICTURE 2 OF 2

PRESSURE AND COVER

Example: one central defender meets the threat while the other provides depth and cover.

WHAT TO LOOK FOR

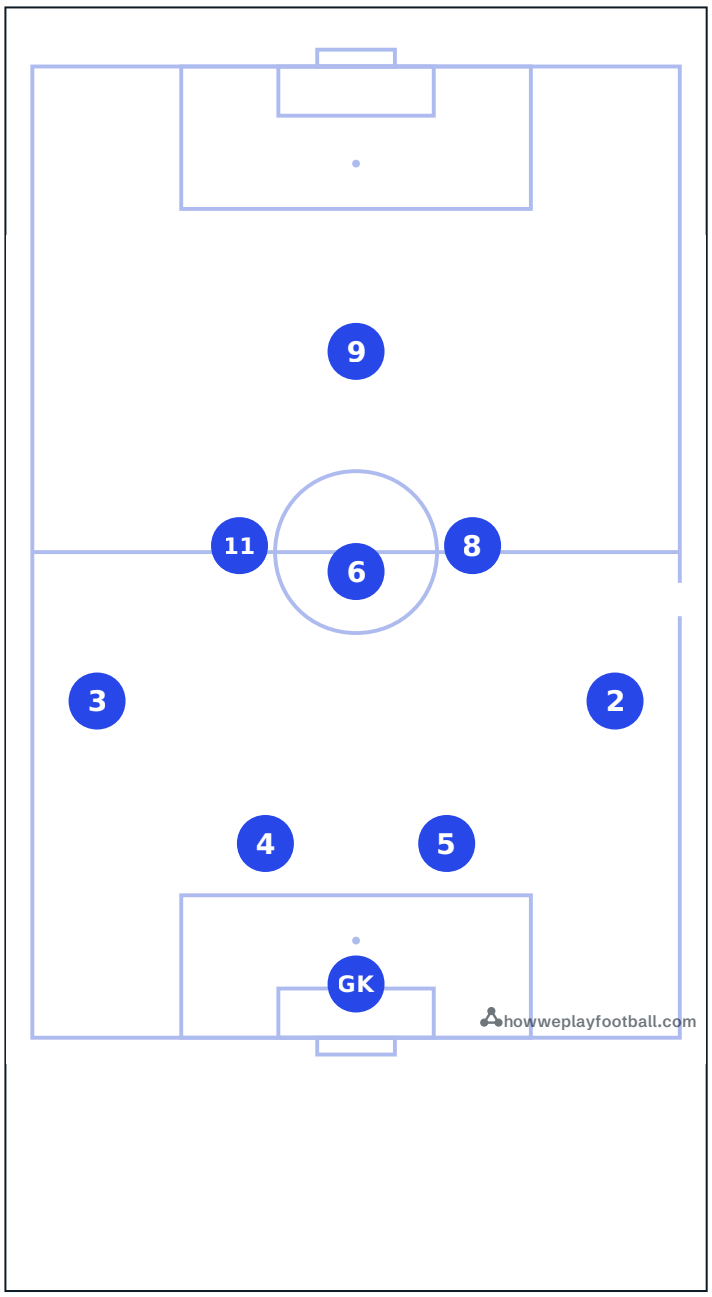
- Do 4 and 5 communicate about who meets the ball?
- Is either defender leaving too much space behind?
- Can one defender help if the other is beaten?

The players can make different choices in different situations. The drawings are illustrative, not fixed moves.

CHAPTER 02 · PRINCIPLE 02 OF 04

WIDTH WITH COVER

Wing-backs go when someone can protect behind. Width can help our attack, but it changes the space we must defend.



PICTURE 1 OF 3

STARTING WIDTH

Starting picture: wing-back 2 provides a ~~wide option with central defenders behind.~~

SAY IT ON THE TOUCHLINE

"IF I GO, WHO COVERS?"

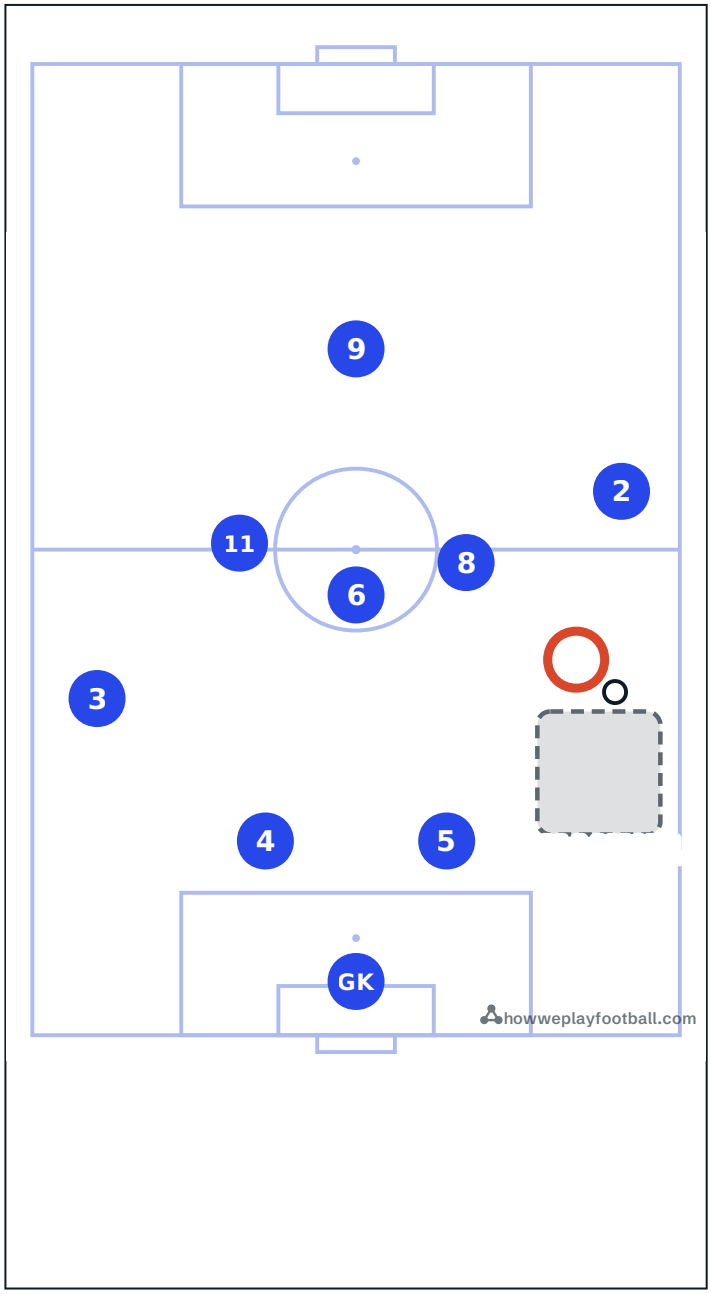
The covering pattern depends on where the ball, defenders and midfielders are.

Move from the first picture to the next to discuss the decision. The drawings are illustrative, not fixed moves.

CHAPTER 02 · PRINCIPLE 02 OF 04

LOOK FOR THIS

Three things to notice when your players make this decision.



PICTURE 3 OF 3

IF WE LOSE IT

Example: after a turnover, the space behind ~~2 becomes the next defensive decision.~~

WHAT TO LOOK FOR

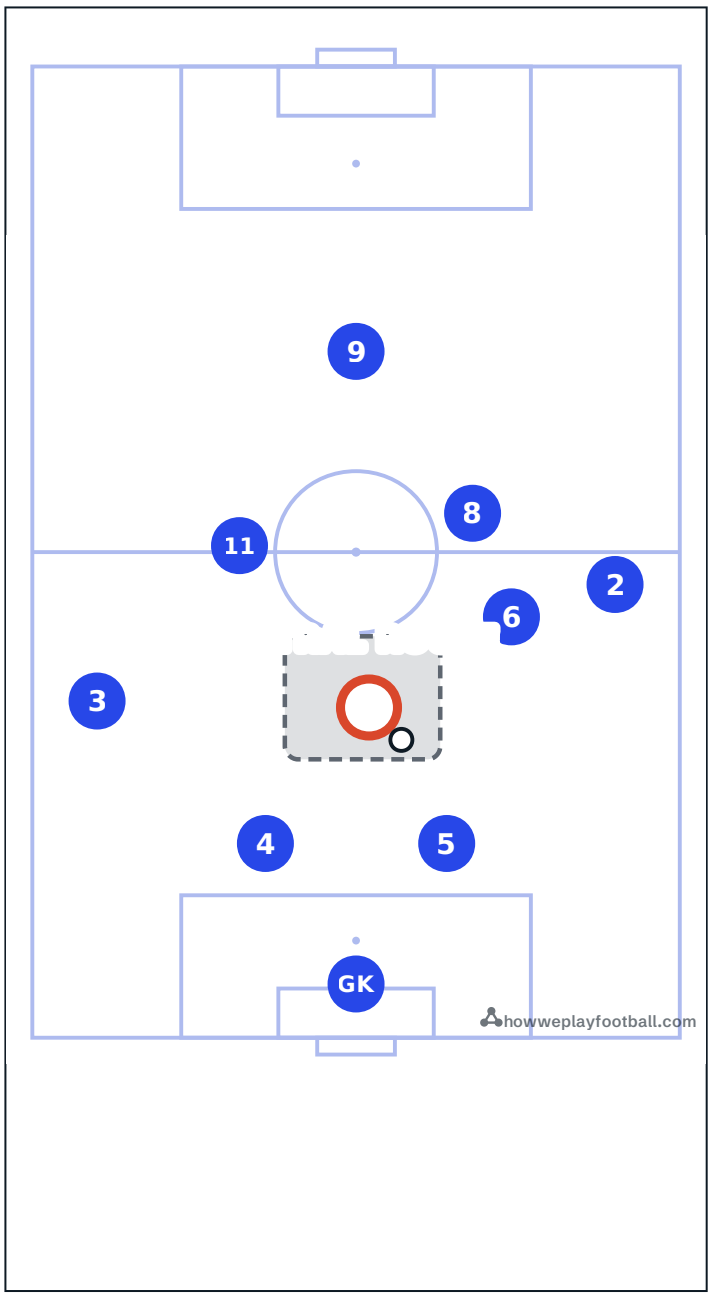
- Is the advancing wing-back offering a useful wide option?
- Which teammate recognises the space left behind?
- Is the distance to recover realistic for this group?

The players can make different choices in different situations. The drawings are illustrative, not fixed moves.

CHAPTER 02 · PRINCIPLE 03 OF 04

SOMEONE PROTECTS THE MIDDLE

Don't leave the route to our goal open. A player must notice central danger when teammates support near the ball.



PICTURE 1 OF 2

MIDDLE LEFT OPEN

Example: the central midfielder follows the ball towards the right while a central route may be exposed.

SAY IT ON THE TOUCHLINE

"WHO IS STOPPING THE PASS THROUGH?"

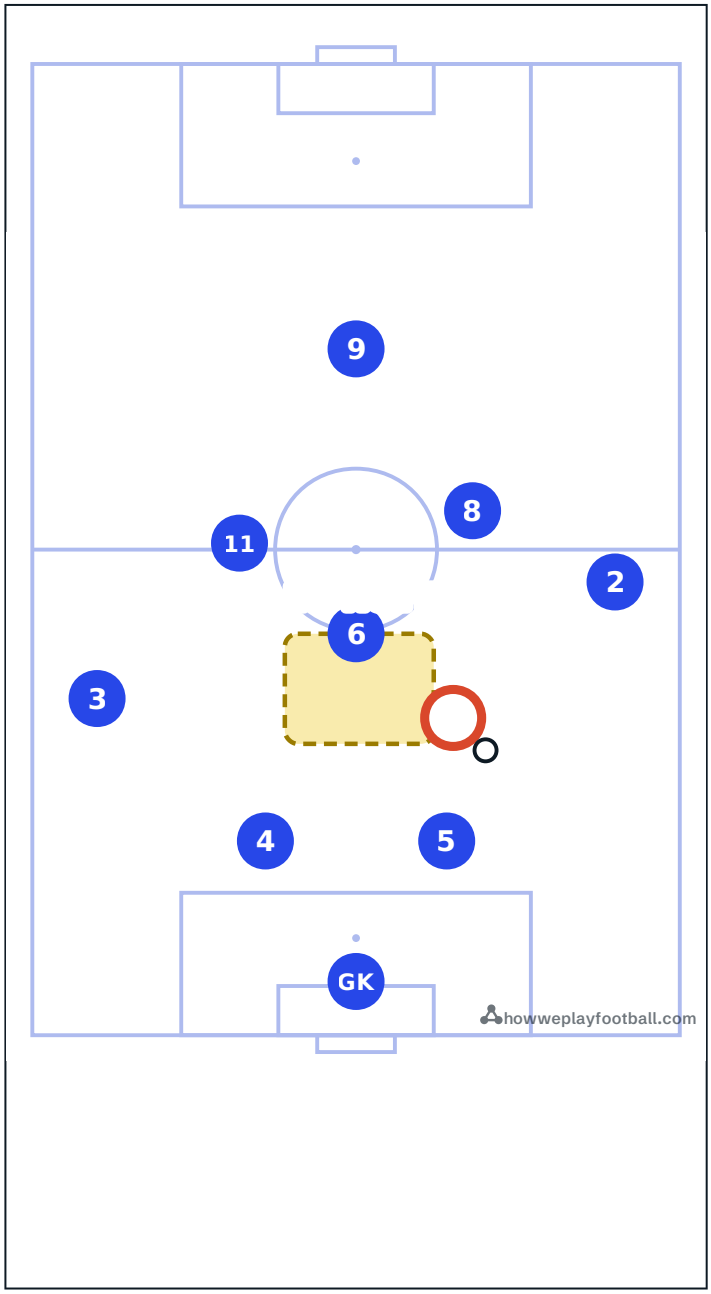
This is a shared team decision, not a permanent instruction for 6 to stay back.

Move from the first picture to the next to discuss the decision. The drawings are illustrative, not fixed moves.

CHAPTER 02 · PRINCIPLE 03 OF 04

LOOK FOR THIS

Three things to notice when your players make this decision.



PICTURE 2 OF 2

PROTECT THE ROUTE

Example: 6 notices the central route and ~~maintains a protective position.~~

WHAT TO LOOK FOR

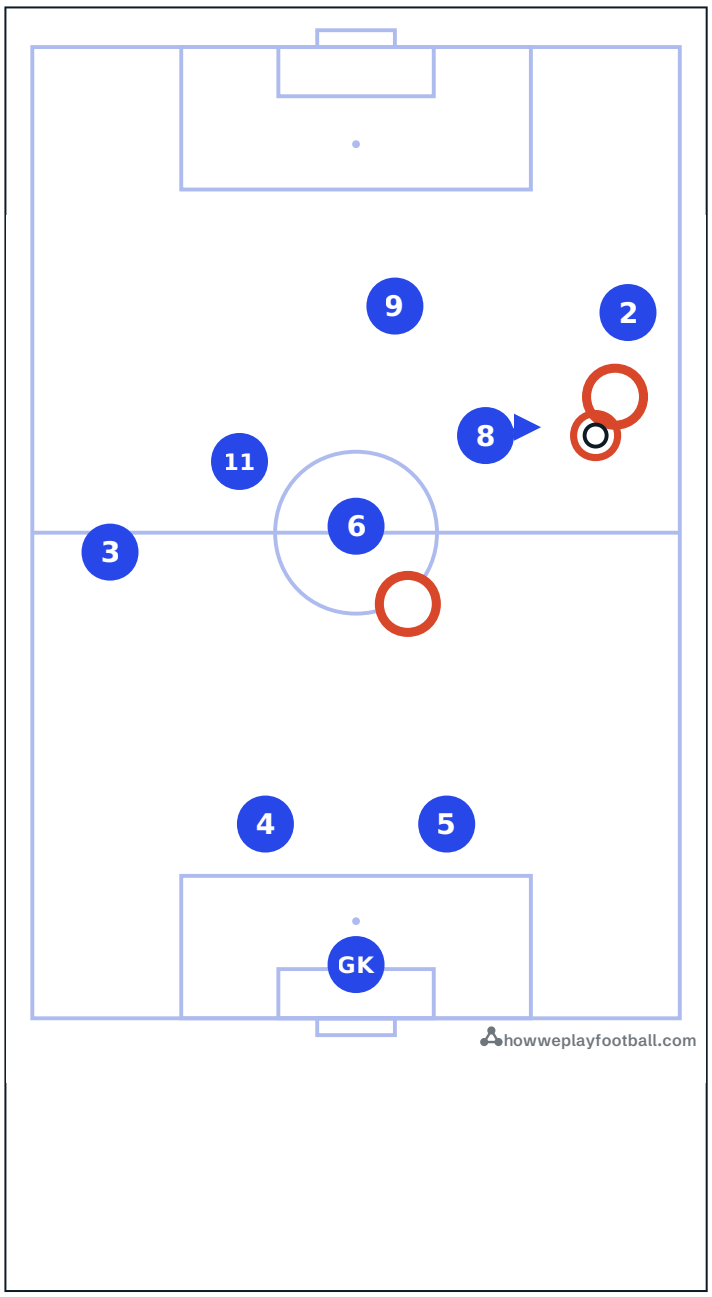
- Do we recognise when the central route is open?
- Can 6 connect play while noticing defensive cover?
- Are the other midfielders helping rather than crowding the same area?

The players can make different choices in different situations. The drawings are illustrative, not fixed moves.

CHAPTER 02 · PRINCIPLE 04 OF 04

LOSE IT? FIND HOME

Press if you can, recover if you can't. After losing the ball, choose the nearest useful defensive job.



PICTURE 1 OF 3

1 · DELAY

We lose it near our right wing-back. The ~~nearest midfielder, 8, delays.~~

SAY IT ON THE TOUCHLINE

"PRESS, PROTECT OR RECOVER: WHICH IS MY JOB?"

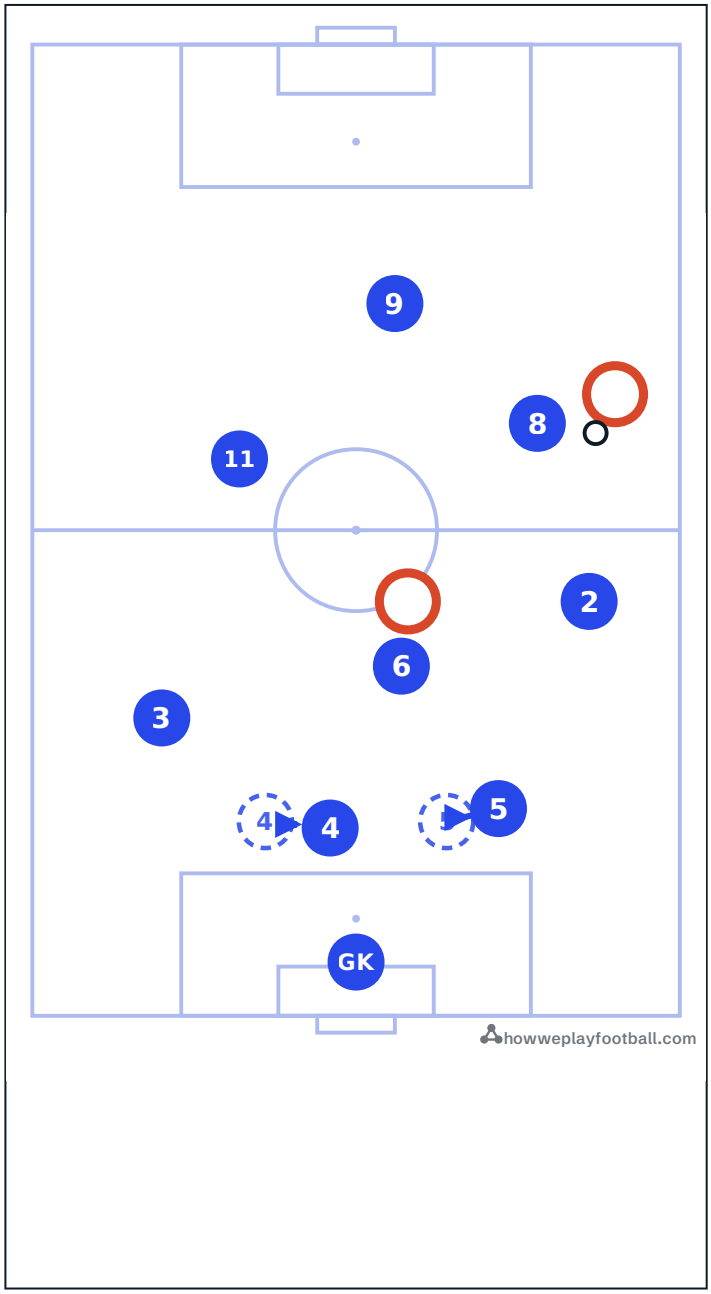
Find home doesn't mean blindly running to a fixed position.

Move from the first picture to the next to discuss the decision. The drawings are illustrative, not fixed moves.

CHAPTER 02 · PRINCIPLE 04 OF 04

LOOK FOR THIS

Three things to notice when your players make this decision.



PICTURE 3 OF 3

3 · MOVE TOGETHER

4 and 5 move together. A back four is only an outcome of real recovery, not an instant switch.

WHAT TO LOOK FOR

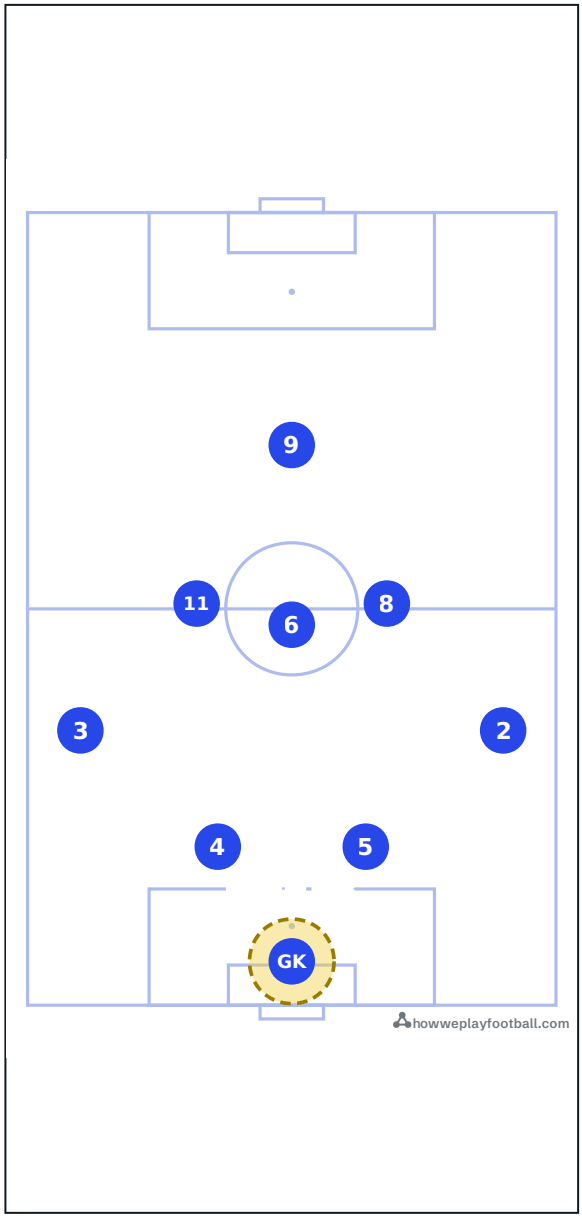
- Can the nearest player delay the opponent with the ball?
- Who covers the central route during the transition?
- Are the wing-back recovery demands appropriate for our players?

The players can make different choices in different situations. The drawings are illustrative, not fixed moves.

CHAPTER 03 · A JOB FOR EVERY PLAYER

GK GOALKEEPER

See danger early



YOUR JOBS

- Notice where the ball might go if the team loses possession.
- Help the two central defenders see and communicate danger.
- Find a sensible passing option rather than forcing play into pressure.

ASK YOURSELF

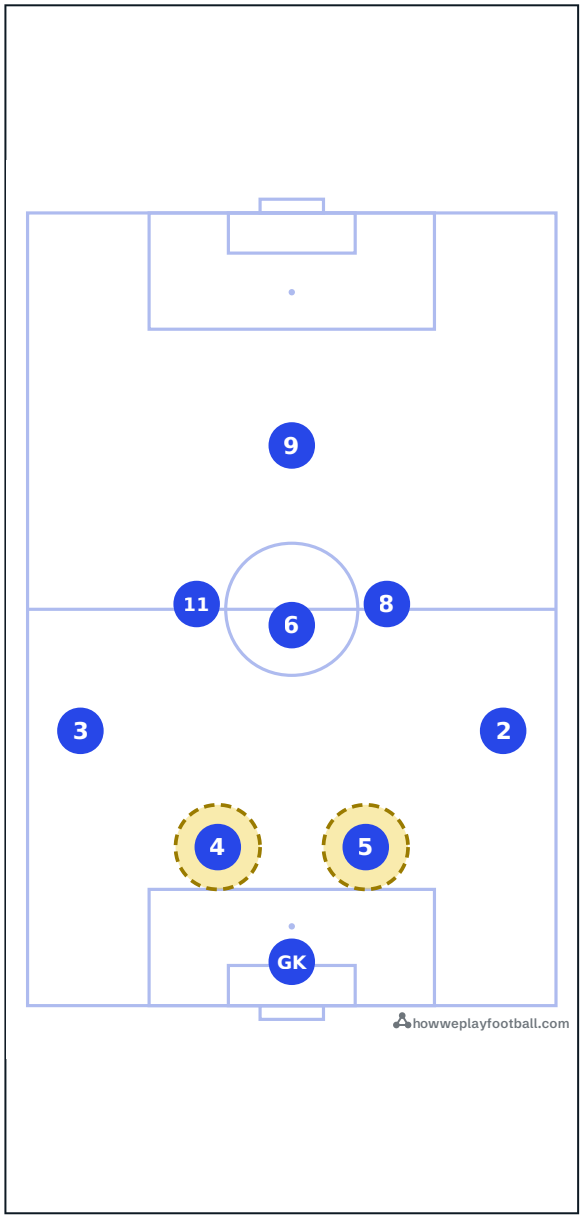
"WHAT COULD HAPPEN IF WE LOSE THIS PASS?"

A starting job, not a fixed position for the whole game.

CHAPTER 03 · A JOB FOR EVERY PLAYER

4 · 5 CENTRAL DEFENDERS

Protect each other



YOUR JOBS

- Stay aware of your partner when deciding whether to challenge.
- Recognise opponents threatening the space behind the wing-backs.
- Help protect the central route when possession changes.

ASK YOURSELF

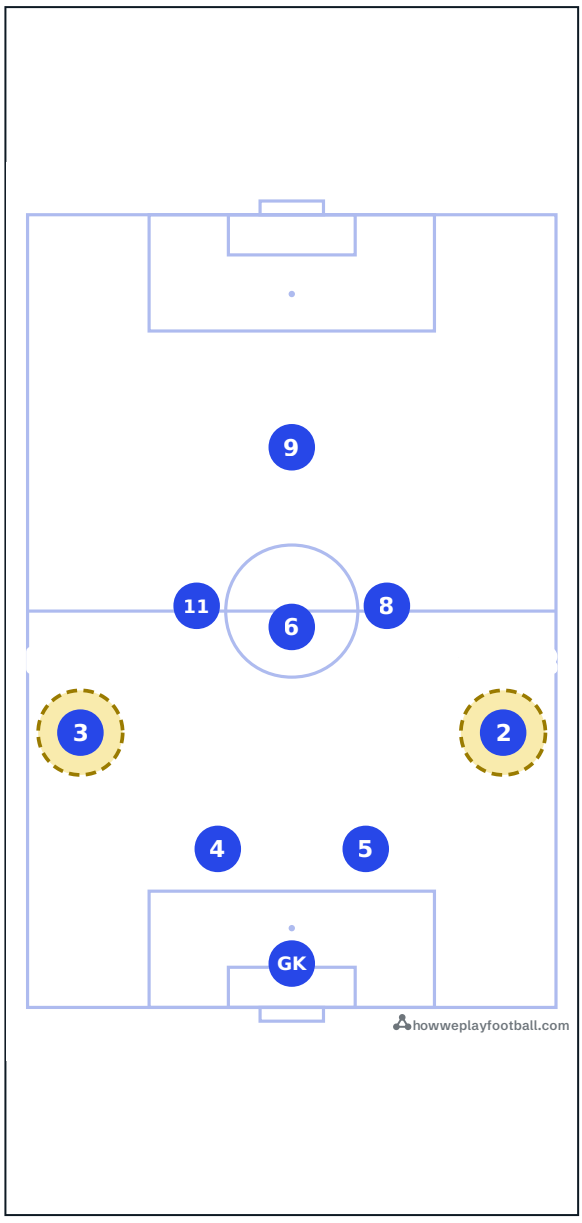
"AM I THE PRESSURE OR THE COVER?"

A starting job, not a fixed position for the whole game.

CHAPTER 03 · A JOB FOR EVERY PLAYER

3 · 2 WING-BACKS

Two jobs, one decision



YOUR JOBS

- Offer a wide option when the team has appropriate cover.
- Recognise who can protect the area left behind when you advance.
- When possession changes, decide whether to delay the ball or recover.

ASK YOURSELF

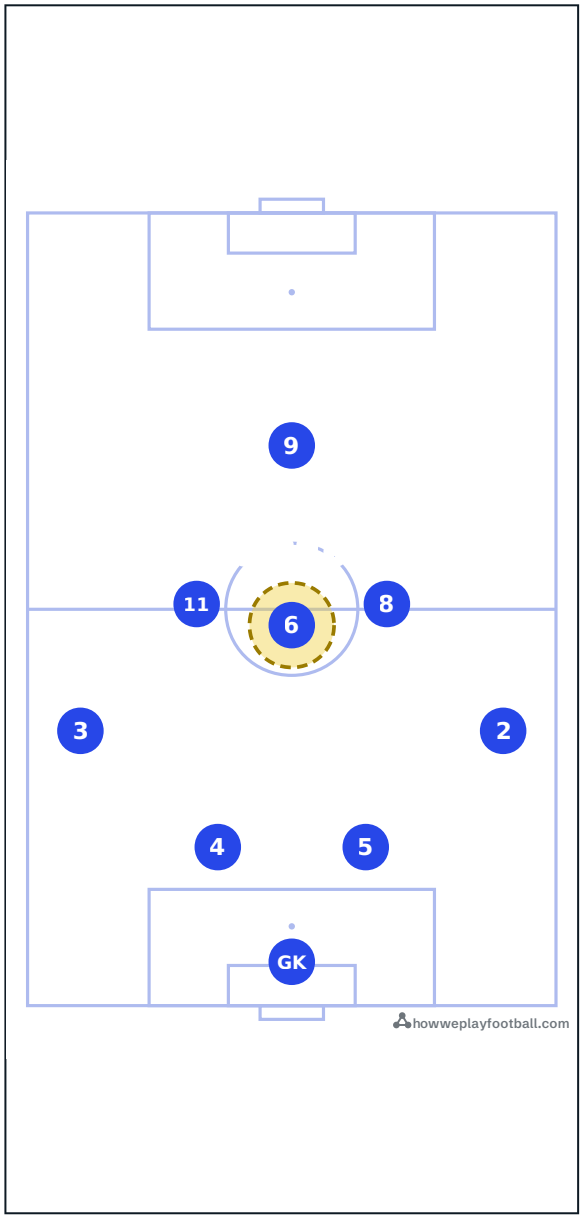
"IF I LEAVE THIS SPACE, WHO HAS IT?"

A starting job, not a fixed position for the whole game.

CHAPTER 03 · A JOB FOR EVERY PLAYER

6 CENTRAL MIDFIELDER

Our connection and protection



YOUR JOBS

- Offer a central passing option without crowding teammates.
- Recognise when an advancing wing-back leaves space to defend.
- Help protect central passes when the team loses the ball.

ASK YOURSELF

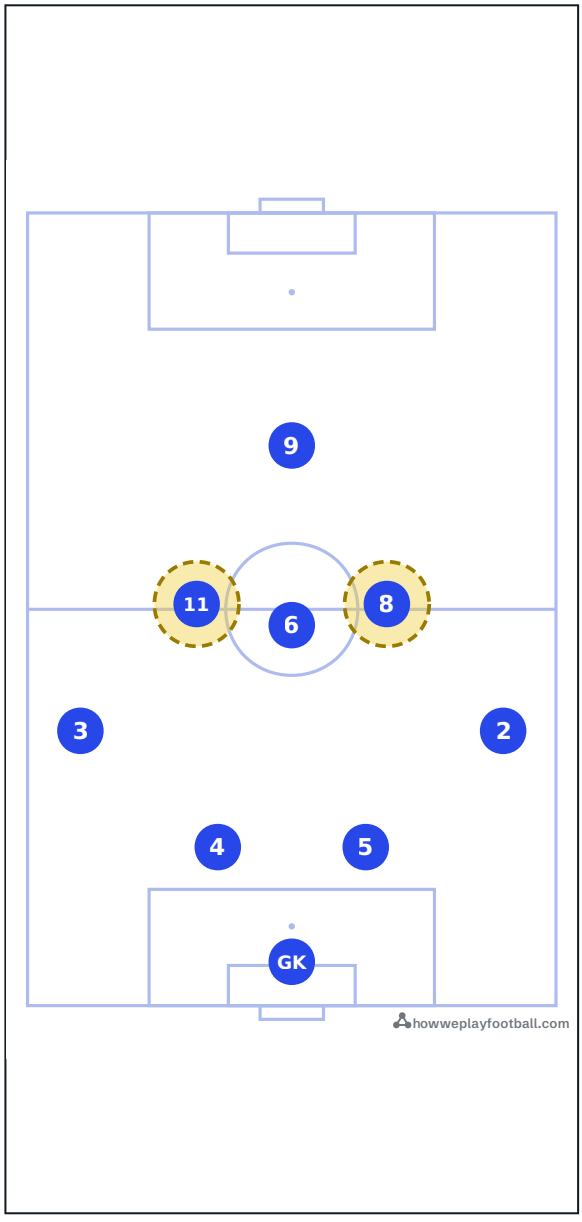
"WHO IS PROTECTING THE MIDDLE?"

A starting job, not a fixed position for the whole game.

CHAPTER 03 · A JOB FOR EVERY PLAYER

11 · 8 INTERIOR MIDFIELDERS

Make angles, not crowds



YOUR JOBS

- Offer different supporting angles to keep possession moving.
- Notice where support is needed when the wing-backs advance.
- Help the team react when possession is lost.

ASK YOURSELF

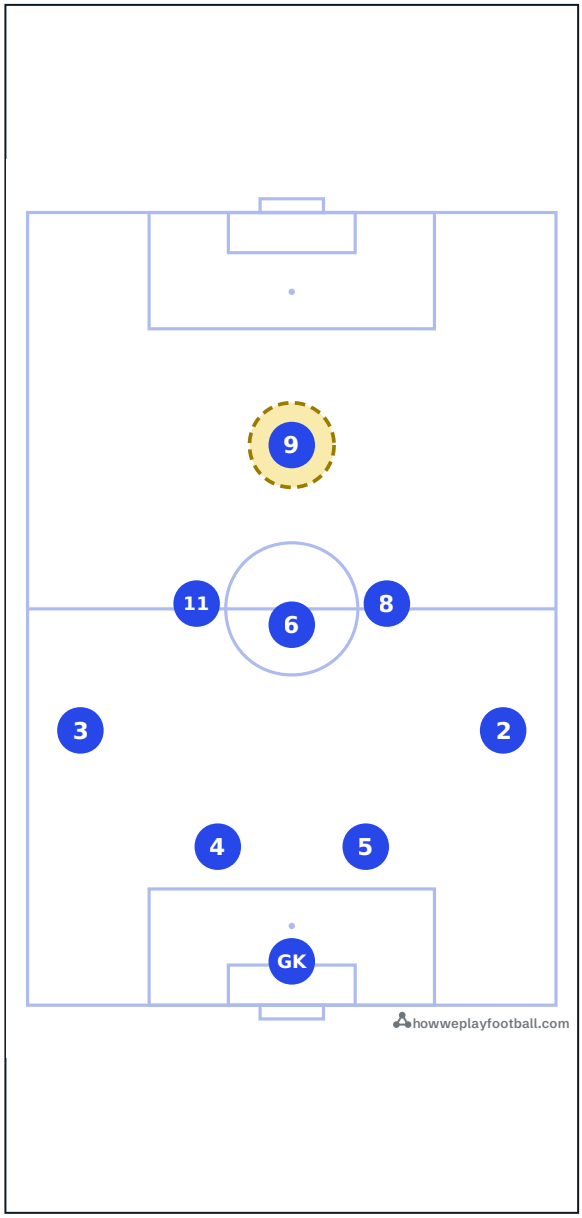
"AM I HELPING THE PLAYER ON THE BALL OR MAKING IT CROWDED?"

A starting job, not a fixed position for the whole game.

CHAPTER 03 · A JOB FOR EVERY PLAYER

9 STRIKER

Give us a way forward



YOUR JOBS

- Make yourself available for a useful pass.
- Look for a teammate close enough to combine with instead of becoming isolated.
- Recognise when to put pressure on the ball and when teammates need recovery time.

ASK YOURSELF

"CAN I RECEIVE, TURN, OR HELP SOMEONE RUN?"

A starting job, not a fixed position for the whole game.

CHAPTER 04 · PLAYING AS A TEAM

PLAYING TOGETHER

A formation only works when players make decisions with each other, with and without the ball.

WHEN WE HAVE THE BALL

PRINCIPLE 2

WIDTH WITH COVER

Width can help our attack, but it changes the space we must defend.

PRINCIPLE 3

SOMEONE PROTECTS THE MIDDLE

A player must notice central danger when teammates support near the ball.

PARTNERSHIP · 3 AND 2

WING-BACKS

Two jobs, one decision

WHEN THEY HAVE THE BALL

PRINCIPLE 1

TWO STAY CONNECTED

The two defenders recognise pressure and cover as a partnership.

PRINCIPLE 4

LOSE IT? FIND HOME

After losing the ball, choose the nearest useful defensive job.

PARTNERSHIP · 4 AND 5

CENTRAL DEFENDERS

Protect each other

COACHING REMINDER

Use the same simple questions in training and on matchday. The picture changes, so the answer may change too.

CHAPTER 04 · KEEP IT SIMPLE

COACHING REMINDERS

All four principles and the player questions in one place.

FOUR PRINCIPLES

01 TWO STAY CONNECTED
“Am I close enough to help?”

02 WIDTH WITH COVER
“If I go, who covers?”

03 SOMEONE PROTECTS THE MIDDLE
“Who is stopping the pass through?”

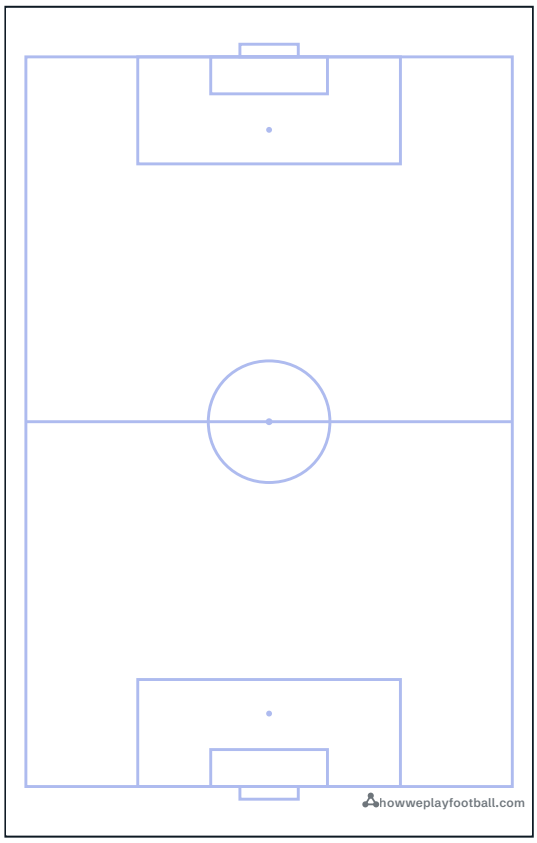
04 LOSE IT? FIND HOME
“Press, protect or recover: which is my job?”

A QUESTION FOR EVERY PLAYER

GK	Goalkeeper	**What could happen if we lose this pass?**
4 · 5	Central defenders	**Am I the pressure or the cover?**
3 · 2	Wing-backs	**If I leave this space, who has it?**
6	Central midfielder	**Who is protecting the middle?**
11 · 8	Interior midfielders	**Am I helping the player on the ball or making it crowded?**
9	Striker	**Can I receive, turn, or help someone run?**

YOUR NOTES

NOTES



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